

CHAPTER 45 — Controlled Detonation

Monday morning, Zoe refused the word release. Ruth Ellison used it once. "We can release the first disclosures at ten."

"No."

Ruth looked at her through the laptop. "No?"

"Release sounds like we're giving everything away."

"We aren't."

"I know."

"What would you call it?"

Zoe looked at the notebook. "Detonation."

Ruth stared at her. Elias, sitting beyond the camera, did not react. "That sounds considerably worse," Ruth said.

"It's supposed to."

"We are not detonating anything."

"We're making it impossible to put back."

Ruth considered. "Controlled disclosure."

"Terrible."

"Legally accurate."

"Controlled detonation."

"No."

Zoe looked at Elias.

"Vote."

"I'm not your tie-breaker."

"Useless."

Ruth almost smiled.

“Controlled disclosure in anything I write.”

“Fine.”

“And you may call it whatever you like in your notebook.”

Zoe wrote:

CONTROLLED DETONATION

Then underlined it.

Once.

No more.

* * *

The drive stayed closed.

So did Zoe’s folder.

That mattered.

They were not proving what adults had done by emptying children’s lives onto desks.

No whole archive.

No school records because they happened to exist.

No medical information.

No current placement addresses.

No sibling locations.

No names from legitimate cases merely because those children had passed through the same organisation.

Zoe had reduced the rules to three.

NO WHOLE-DRIVE DUMP.

NO CHILDREN USED TO PROVE WHAT ADULTS DID.

NO ONE GETS THE ONLY COPY OF THE TRUTH.

Ruth read them.

"The second one needs qualifications in the real world."

"I know."

"For example, Jackie's own information may be necessary to investigate what happened to Jackie."

"I know."

"And some child information may become relevant to lawful safeguarding or criminal proceedings."

"I know."

Ruth paused.

"You're getting less argumentative."

"Don't worry. It won't last."

Good.

The rest belonged to adults who knew how evidence rules worked.

Ruth.

Priya.

Independent counsel.

Investigators.

Zoe did not need to design every envelope.

She only needed to know what she would not agree to.

* * *

By half past eight, the disclosures were ready.

Not sent.

Ready.

North Vale and Westmere would receive the material needed to examine their own records and authority.

Police would receive the contractor evidence, current-coercion material they were already entitled to handle, and the relevant verification records.

Mac's independent solicitor would continue transferring his sponsor, payment and adult-process records through the formal route already opened.

Daniel Rusk would receive the smallest package of all.

Not the archive.

Not Jackie's statement.

Not Helen and Brian's full accounts.

Not child files.

A short chronology.

A redacted North Vale contradiction.

Confirmation that Voss and Vale had signed statements.

A redacted page showing AC019 attached to a real adult sponsor.

And enough information about Westmere's preservation process to ask the institution whether any of it was true.

Daniel was not getting the story.

He was getting questions.

Ruth had checked him first.

Safeguarding reporting.

Institutional failures.

Source protection.

No history of publishing vulnerable children for drama.

That did not make him trustworthy.

It made him worth testing.

At eight forty-seven, he called.

Ruth put him on speaker.

"This is thin."

Zoe smiled.

"Good."

A pause.

"Is that Zoe?"

"Yes," Ruth said.

Daniel recovered quickly.

"If you want me to publish, I need enough to support what I'm saying."

"You have enough to start."

"That's not necessarily enough to finish."

"Then don't finish yet."

Silence. Elias looked at the wall. Probably to avoid smiling. Daniel said:
"You're not giving me the archive."

"No."

"Can I see it?"

"No."

"Can I speak to Voss and Vale?"

"If they agree."

"North Vale?"

"Yes."

"Westmere?"

"Yes."

"Mac?"

"His lawyer."

"Helen and Brian?"

"No."

"Why not?"

Zoe looked at Ruth. Ruth did not interfere. "Because you don't need them yet."

"They're central to your case."

"To mine."

Daniel waited.

"You need to prove the system before you use my family to prove it."

That quieted him.

"Fair."

"What are you asking North Vale?"

"Whether the supplemental authority existed."

"Westmere?"

"Whether the restricted cases are genuinely under review and whether records were preserved."

"Voss and Vale?"

"Whether the signed statements exist and whether their account is consistent with the authority contradiction."

"Mac's lawyer?"

"Whether the sponsor agreement is authentic."

Zoe nodded.

Daniel could not see it.

"Ask them separately."

"I was planning to."

"Without telling one what the other said."

"Yes."

"I want to know whether they give you the same answer without hearing each other first."

Daniel laughed softly.

"That is normally how verification works."

"Good."

"Anything else?"

"Yes."

"What?"

"If one of them tells you something bigger than what you can prove, don't make it bigger because it sounds better."

No laugh that time.

"Understood."

* * *

At nine twenty, Mac sat with his solicitor waiting for police.

He had agreed to attend voluntarily.

Interview under caution.

Represented.

No immunity.

No promise that cooperation would prevent arrest.

His solicitor went through that last point again.

"They may change your status during the interview."

"I understand."

"They may arrest you before it begins."

"I understand."

"Disclosure does not protect you from prosecution."

"I know."

"Do you still want to proceed?"

Mac looked down at the table.

Years ago, Brian had been sitting across from him somewhere much less formal.

A drink.

A conversation.

A man in pain.

Mac saying he knew people.

That was the part he remembered most clearly now.

Not because it excused what came later.

Because it did not look important enough to become what it became.

One favour.

One route around a rule.

Then another.

Then money.

Then people who knew who to call.

By the time children had become account numbers, nobody had needed to invent the system.

They had already built it.

Mac said:

"Yes."

* * *

Helen was reviewing her own statement at the kitchen table.

Brian had his separately.

Neither was allowed to read the other's.

Helen reached the final page.

One paragraph stopped her.

Not because it described the glass.

Or Mac.

Or what she knew about the missing lawful process.

She had already said all of that.

The paragraph was one she had dictated herself.

Nothing about the care we later gave Zoe made the original decision ours to make.

She read it again.

Brian looked up.

"You okay?"

"No."

He nodded.

That was all.

* * *

Jackie burned toast.

Nobody stopped her.

That was the most interesting thing happening to Jackie at nine forty in the morning.

Claire had told her the investigation might become public later.

Jackie said:

“Tell me after.”

“After what?”

“After it actually exists.”

She had spent enough time trapped inside events nobody else knew were happening.

She was not going to spend Monday staring at a screen waiting for adults to decide whether reality qualified as news.

So she went downstairs in the boring house and made breakfast.

The toast came out black.

Maria, one of the staff, looked at it.

“There’s more bread.”

“Not the point.”

“What is the point?”

“I committed.”

Maria stared at the toast.

“That’s not how food works.”

“Exactly what someone without principles would say.”

Maria laughed.

Jackie ate it.

It was awful.

Entirely her own fault.

Excellent.

* * *

Before ten, Daniel started checking.

He called North Vale without mentioning Zoe.

Read the redacted reference.

The base reference existed.

The supplemental authority did not appear in their records.

He asked whether North Vale could confirm the powers attributed to that supplemental document had been lawfully issued.

They could not.

He asked whether the matter was being reviewed.

The spokesperson answered carefully.

“A historic records review is under way concerning possible unauthorised use of local-authority legal identity in a safeguarding matter.”

Daniel wrote it down.

Then called Westmere.

Different questions.

Different organisation.

Westmere confirmed that a restricted historic subset was being examined and records had been preserved.

Daniel asked:

“How many placements?”

They would not say.

“Are all Westmere placements implicated?”

“No.”

That answer came quickly.

The spokesperson repeated it.

Most historic safeguarding work was not part of the concern.

Daniel underlined the sentence.

Good.

Not:

Westmere stole children.

Not:

all safeguarding was corrupt.

A legitimate institution.

A restricted pathway inside it.

He called Priya next.

She confirmed that Voss and Vale had signed statements.

Would not send them.

Would not identify children.

Daniel asked:

“Do they admit knowingly moving children on forged orders?”

“No.”

That mattered.

“What do they admit?”

Priya’s answer was annoyingly precise.

“At least one historic recovery was carried out after they relied on a supplied verification route which is now materially contradicted by the purported issuing authority.”

Daniel wrote that down too.

No cleaner than it was.

No worse.

* * *

At ten, Ruth looked at Zoe through the screen.

“Ready?”

The question was not ceremonial.

Zoe could still say no.

Or not yet.

Or send only part.

The folder remained beside her.

The drive remained inside the backpack.

Elias was by the window.

Not voting.

Not deciding.

Zoe looked at Ruth.

“No whole archive.”

“No whole archive.”

“No Jackie to the press.”

“Agreed.”

“No child names unless the people legally handling that child actually need them.”

“Subject to their duties, yes.”

“And Daniel gets what he already has.”

“For now.”

Zoe nodded.

“Do it.”

Ruth sent the disclosures.

Nothing flashed.

No countdown.

No progress bar. Four ordinary emails. Ten o'clock. That was the detonation.

* * *

Within twenty minutes, the first acknowledgements arrived. North Vale. Westmere. The police route. Mac's counsel. Voss and Vale's signed material was formally logged. Helen and Brian's statements entered restricted handling. Daniel started sending questions to organisations Zoe had never contacted. The evidence was moving without her. Zoe watched the receiver for another minute. Then switched it off. Elias looked over. “Problem?”

“No.”

“Then why?”

“I don't want to watch every minute.”

He nodded. “That's it?”

“Yes.”

“It feels bigger.”

“It is.”

She waited for something else.

Nothing came.

Annoying.

They went for a walk.

* * *

By late morning, Cain had heard from four different directions.

Police wanted vehicle records preserved.

Legacy legal had received formal evidence demands.

Meridian's current directors were retaining specified historic records.

North Vale and Westmere were no longer dealing with the problem as an internal irregularity.

Cain sat in a multistorey car park and watched families loading shopping into cars.

He called restricted legal.

Her solicitor answered.

"Do not contact my client directly."

Cain ended the call.

Called Mac.

Nothing.

Margaret.

Nothing.

A field coordinator rang him before he could try anyone else. "Police want vehicle records."

"Which?"

"Historic jobs. Some current."

"Jackie?"

"Yes."

Cain looked up at the camera over the exit. "Delete nothing."

The coordinator went quiet. Cain heard himself. For once it was the correct instruction. Too late to mean anything good. "They also want to interview me."

"Get counsel first."

Another pause. "I already did."

Cain closed his eyes. "Fine."

"What?"

"Get your own lawyer."

The man sounded genuinely surprised. Years earlier, Cain would have treated that as disloyalty. Now even he could see the shape of what had happened.

Nobody wanted the same lawyer anymore.

Nobody wanted the same story.

Every person had started protecting their own piece.

The call ended.

Cain looked at the exit.

He could leave.

Airport.

Ferry.

Cash.

Another car.

Another property.

Except every route required somebody else.

And everybody else had begun keeping records.

* * *

At eleven forty, police attended the legacy legal administrator by arrangement.

No raid.

No doors broken.

Two officers.

A digital-forensics specialist.

The company's solicitor.

The woman who had refused Cain stood in the corridor while the relevant systems were preserved.

Adult user accounts.

Routing records.

Verification logs.

Templates.

Timestamps.

Child-identifying information restricted where it was not necessary for the immediate evidential task.

Years of ordinary work sat beside the problem.

That was what made her feel sick.

Most of what she had done had looked like ordinary legal administration because much of it had been.

Real cases.

Real confidentiality.

Real vulnerable families.

Then, inside it, instructions that should never have existed.

The technician sealed the copied material into an evidence bag.

The woman signed the handover.

Her hand shook.

She signed anyway.

* * *

Shortly after noon, Daniel got confirmation from Mac's solicitor.

The sponsor agreement was authentic.

Mac's signature was genuine.

AC019 belonged to him.

The agreement related to private placement-support referrals through restricted channels.

The solicitor did not confirm that every referral was unlawful. Would not confirm allegations not yet established. Daniel wrote in his notes:

AC019 IS REAL.

Then underneath:

THAT DOES NOT MAKE EVERY REFERRAL CRIMINAL.

Good. He called Ruth. "I have enough to describe the architecture."

"Not Zoe."

"I know."

"Not Jackie."

"I know."

"Not recipient identities."

"I know."

"Not Westmere as a criminal organisation."

"I know."

Daniel sighed. "Do you think I haven't done this before?"

Zoe was sitting beside Ruth's image on the screen. "We're checking."

He laughed. "Of course you are."

His plan was a first report.

Not the final answer.

Not an exposé claiming hundreds of stolen children.

A narrow public fact:

historic safeguarding authority was under review after documents attributed to public bodies were contradicted by those bodies.

Contractors had signed statements.

A real private sponsor existed.

A restricted placement pathway was being examined inside legitimate safeguarding infrastructure.

Police were preserving records.

No child names.

No claim about scale they could not support.

Four o'clock, if nothing collapsed under checking.

* * *

At twelve forty-seven, police called Cain.

They asked him to attend regarding Jackie's movement and related historic matters.

"Through my solicitor."

"Do you currently have one?"

"Yes."

He did not.

Not one who would still act on the old terms.

The officer continued.

"We are advising you not to contact Jackie, her current safeguarding team or potential witnesses."

"Advising?"

"Yes."

"Am I under arrest?"

"Not at this stage."

Cain looked towards the car-park exit.

"Am I free to leave?"

"You are not under arrest."

Not the same answer.

Cain noticed.

For once he did not try to force a better one from the wording.

He ended the call and started searching for a solicitor.

* * *

By early afternoon, Helen and Brian had both signed their statements.

Separately.

Restricted handling.

Zoe did not read them.

Ruth told her only that neither had withdrawn the admissions made the day before.

"That's it?"

"That's it."

"They didn't change it?"

"No."

"Good."

Ruth paused.

"One sentence in Helen's statement concerns you directly. You can decide whether you want to hear it."

Zoe stared at the floor.

“What kind?”

“Not a request for forgiveness. Not a request for contact.”

That helped.

“Read it.”

Ruth did.

“Nothing about the care we later gave Zoe made the original decision ours to make.”

Zoe did not answer.

The sentence did not fix anything.

Good.

She was getting suspicious of sentences that tried.

Finally:

“Stop there.”

Ruth stopped.

* * *

Voss and Vale repeated their accounts to police with solicitors present.

Different rooms.

Different voices.

The facts remained broadly the same as what they had signed.

Voss accepted that he had relied on the supplied chain instead of verifying outside it.

Vale accepted that she had stood beside him and carried out the work.

The officer interviewing Vale asked:

“Why come forward now?”

Vale thought for a long time.

Then said:

“I used to think not knowing the whole thing meant I wasn’t part of it.”

She looked at the recorder.

“It didn’t.”

That was enough.

* * *

At two thirty-eight, Mac’s voluntary cooperation became an arrest.

No raid.

No shouting.

He was already inside the interview suite with his solicitor when the investigating officer returned.

The officer explained that his status had changed.

Suspicion connected to unlawful child placement.

Fraudulent documentation.

Interference with safeguarding processes.

Financial offences.

The exact allegations would develop with the evidence.

Mac was cautioned.

His solicitor turned to him.

“Do you understand?”

“Yes.”

“Do you still intend to cooperate?”

Mac looked at the sealed P06 material on the table.

Then at the officer.

"Yes."

No handcuffs.

No cameras.

The room stayed the same.

His control over what happened inside it did not.

* * *

At three ten, Jackie was asked whether she wanted to give a recorded video interview.

"Today?"

"No. We can arrange it."

"Do I have to?"

"No."

"Can I stop?"

"Yes."

"Can I do audio instead?"

"That's something you and Nisha can discuss with us."

Jackie thought.

"Can I see Zoe first?"

Claire did not answer immediately.

Good.

Then:

"That may be possible. But seeing Zoe is not something you have to earn by giving us an interview."

Jackie stared at her.

Also good.

"Do I need to decide now?"

"No."

"Then no."

"No to the interview?"

"No to deciding."

Claire smiled.

"Okay."

Jackie found herself not hating the word.

Interesting.

Maybe okay was different when somebody had actually asked first.

* * *

At three thirty, Daniel sent the draft headline.

Historic safeguarding placements under review after authority documents contradicted by councils

Zoe stared.

"Plural?"

Ruth answered:

"More than one restricted case is now being reviewed."

"Reviewed isn't proved."

"The headline says reviewed."

Zoe read the subheading.

Contractors, legal administrators and a private sponsor have provided records suggesting a restricted placement pathway operated inside legitimate child-protection infrastructure.

“Inside legitimate infrastructure.”

“Yes.”

“Not Westmere was fake.”

“No.”

“Good.”

The article was careful.

North Vale confirmed that one purported supplemental authority could not be found and the powers attributed to it were not supported by its records.

Westmere confirmed a restricted historic subset was being examined.

Most of its past work was not implicated.

Two former contractors had signed accounts describing reliance on a supplied verification route now contradicted by the supposed issuing authority.

A private sponsor had authenticated records linking him to placement-support referrals.

Police were preserving related records.

No child was named.

Zoe was not named.

Jackie was not named.

Helen and Brian were not named.

Daniel included another section.

WHAT IS NOT ESTABLISHED

No evidence that all Westmere placements were unlawful.

No verified total number of affected children.

No evidence that every member of staff knew about the restricted route.

No basis to claim every receiving household had the same level of knowledge.

Zoe went back over the section.

Better.

Daniel asked:

“Publish?”

Ruth said:

“From my side, the draft remains within what has been verified.”

Zoe looked at Elias.

He was standing by the door.

Not answering for her.

Good.

She looked back at the screen.

“What if one of the other cases turns out to be normal?”

Ruth said:

“Then it should be recorded as normal.”

“What if Westmere gets destroyed anyway?”

“That risk exists.”

“What if families panic?”

“That risk exists.”

No comforting lie.

Zoe appreciated it.

“What if we wait?”

“The investigations continue,” Ruth said. “The records remain preserved.”

“And public?”

“Still quiet.”

Zoe looked at the headline.

Once it existed publicly, nobody could put every question back in the room.

That was the point.

Not punishment.

Not spectacle.

Resilience.

“Publish.”

* * *

At four, Daniel did.

For eleven seconds, nothing changed.

Then the article began moving.

Another outlet cited North Vale.

A local reporter contacted Westmere.

Westmere issued a statement confirming an independent historic review while warning families not to assume an individual placement was unlawful merely because Westmere had been involved.

North Vale confirmed its own records review.

Another public body announced it was checking historic cases routed through the same legal-administration channel.

Meridian’s current directors confirmed they had retained independent counsel.

Police acknowledged an investigation into historic safeguarding documentation and a current safeguarding matter.

Nobody named a child.

Then the internet arrived.

Zoe looked once.

Thousands of stolen children.

Secret government programme.

Foreign buyers.

Things involving organs.

She closed the page.

"That took twelve minutes."

"About normal," Ruth said.

"That is horrifying."

"Yes."

Daniel updated the article.

The What is not established section moved higher.

Good.

People could invent whatever they wanted.

They did not get to change what the evidence actually said.

* * *

At four forty, Cain found a new solicitor. He was parked in a lay-by off the A49. The article sat open on his phone. The photograph was of Westmere. Not him. That was worse. The article did not need him to make the architecture visible. Private sponsor. Contractor evidence. Verification route. Public authority contradiction. Preserved records. Different pieces held by different people. Cain called the solicitor. "Do not move," the man said.

"I'm not moving."

"Do not contact anyone connected to the investigation."

"I haven't."

"Do not delete anything."

"I haven't."

A pause. "Where are you?"

Cain looked through the windscreen.

He almost lied.

Then:

"Lay-by off the A49."

"Which one?"

Cain gave the nearest junction and marker.

"Police want to arrange contact. Do I have your authority to give them your location?"

Cain looked at the road.

Engine still running.

He could say no.

Drive south.

Turn west.

Find cash.

Find another vehicle.

Another person.

Another route.

Every option now required someone who might later sit in a room and say:

He called me.

Cain turned the engine off.

"Yes."

The solicitor repeated it.

"You authorise me to provide your location?"

"Yes."

"I will arrange it."

The call ended.

Cain sat in the quiet car.

Not surrender.

Recognition.

There was nowhere left that did not produce more evidence.

* * *

At five twelve, two police vehicles entered the lay-by.

No chase.

No gun.

No Elias.

Cain stepped out when asked.

Hands visible.

An officer confirmed his name.

Cautioned him.

Then arrested him on suspicion of offences connected to Jackie's detention and movement, interference with safeguarding processes, and related historic matters.

Cain looked down the road.

"Is Mac talking?"

The officer said:

"I'm not discussing other suspects."

Cain almost smiled.

Of course.

Compartmentalisation.

Legitimate this time.

The rear door closed behind him.

No speech.

No fight.

A man who had spent years deciding where other people went was now being moved under authority he had no part in creating.

* * *

Zoe learned just before six.

Mac in custody.

Cain in custody.

Separate investigations.

No charges yet.

No victory speech arrived.

She sat on the edge of the bed.

Elias waited.

"That's it?"

"No."

She knew.

There would be interviews.

Court hearings.

Evidence arguments.

Children.

Families.

People who lied.

People who remembered badly. Some allegations that held. Some that might not. Years, probably. Nothing became clean because two men were inside police buildings. Still. Zoe looked at Elias. "They can't recover me tonight."

He considered. "Not through the routes we know."

She rolled her eyes. "Can you ever just say yes?"

"When it's true."

Annoying. Useful. The word RECOVER no longer felt like an instruction. For weeks it had moved people. Vehicles. Money. Lawyers. Now it existed in preserved records for investigators to ask about. That mattered.

* * *

Ruth called once more that evening.

Zoe answered.

"No giant status list."

Ruth paused.

"I wasn't going to give you one."

"You were thinking about it."

"Possibly."

Zoe smiled.

"What matters?"

"One thing."

"Go on."

"The public case no longer depends on your archive being available."

Zoe went still.

Ruth continued.

"Investigators will still need original material where relevant. The drive remains important. But destroying it now would not erase the authority contradiction, the signed statements, Mac's records, the preserved legal logs or the institutional reviews."

Zoe looked at the backpack.

There.

That was what she had needed to know.

Not that everything was finished.

That it could no longer be put back inside one bag.

She opened the notebook.

For a moment she considered writing:

DETONATION COMPLETE

No. Too final. She wrote one word instead.

IRREVERSIBLE

Then closed it.

* * *

"Tomorrow I want to see Jackie." Elias looked up. "If Jackie still wants that and safeguarding agrees." "She does." "Then likely." Zoe smiled. "She stole that from you." "Yes." "And Helen and Brian?" Elias did not answer. Good. Zoe thought of the statements she had not read. The letter they had permission to write. Facts first. Love later. Maybe.

"I don't know," she said.

Elias nodded.

That answer did not need fixing.

* * *

The drive came last.

Zoe took the backpack onto the bed and removed both things she had stolen from the archive.

The hard drive.

The numbered folder.

She set them side by side.

They had travelled together for so long that part of her had begun treating them as the same object.

They were not.

The drive contained a system.

The folder contained her.

Ruth had already explained the options.

The archive drive could enter protected evidence handling under documented conditions.

Copies already existed elsewhere.

Access to child-identifying material would remain controlled.

The original would no longer travel in Zoe's bag.

The folder was different.

It was her personal history.

Her placement.

Her payments.

Her origin record.

The things other people had written about her before she was old enough to object.

Zoe called Ruth.

"I don't want the folder going in with the drive."

"It doesn't have to."

"Where does it go?"

"If you want, I can hold it separately as your solicitor, under your instructions. It would not become part of the general evidential handover merely because I'm holding it."

"Can police get it?"

"They could potentially seek relevant material through lawful process. I cannot promise the folder is beyond every legal request."

"Good."

Ruth waited.

"But it stays mine?"

"The document itself may contain records created by others, so ownership in the strict property sense may be more complicated than that."

Zoe stared at the phone.

"Ruth."

Ruth sighed.

"You decide what I do with it unless and until a lawful obligation requires otherwise."

"Better."

"And I would tell you if that changed."

Zoe looked at the folder.

"Then you keep it."

"Separately?"

"Yes."

"Sealed?"

"Yes."

"No copying without telling me?"

"Subject to legal obligations, yes."

"Fine."

Ruth paused.

"Tomorrow?"

"Yes."

"The evidence officer can receive the drive at the same meeting. Separate receipt. Separate handling."

Good.

The system could leave.

Her history did not have to disappear into it.

Zoe put the folder into a plain envelope.

Sealed it.

Wrote her own name across the flap.

Not P06-11803.

Not a recipient code.

Not an account number.

ZOE

She looked at it.

Then at the drive. Elias had stayed by the window throughout the call. She said: "I don't want to carry that anymore."

He looked at the drive. "Then don't."

"That easy?"

"The paperwork won't be."

She groaned. "Of course."

"There will be receipts."

"Thrilling."

"Signatures."

"Stop."

"Possibly more than one."

"I hate evidence."

"No, you don't."

Zoe looked at the hard drive. "No."

She didn't. She was just tired of wearing it. For weeks the backpack had been behind her shoulders. Bus.

Car.

Hotel.

Cottage.

Farmhouse.

Café.

Everywhere.

Proof.

Threat.

Responsibility.

By morning it would be evidence somebody else had a legal duty to carry.

The folder would go to Ruth separately.

The drive would go into protected handling.

The backpack would come back.

Zoe zipped it closed.

Lighter already.

Monday ended without another message.

Without another alert.

Without another diagram.

Tomorrow morning, she would give the drive away.